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COMMENTARY: Library in no danger of becoming 'doomed'



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Last week on the electronic mailing list for Idaho librarians, a message was posted with the subject "Are Libraries Doomed?"

Typically I don't read messages like this, because I don't believe much will happen to lead to the doom of bedrock social or governmental institutions like libraries, schools, the post office, churches, political parties, etc.

A message like this is either highly misguided, or has an inflammatory subject line to get people's attention. I was set to ignore the message until, of course, everyone I work with got in an uproar over it.

The "doom" was extrapolated from an Associated Press article dated Aug. 21 that ran in many newspapers nationwide and was featured on CNN's Web site. The point of the article was that people aren't reading as many books as they used to. According to a survey the article quotes, 25 percent of Americans didn't read any books at all last year.

So what? I know a lot of people who probably didn't read any books last year, but that doesn't mean they didn't read at all. The article doesn't say that fewer people are reading, just that some people didn't read books. I have a friend who reads magazines. He has subscriptions to all that are really important to him, like

Sports Illustrated, New Republic, and a few other less mentionable titles. In 20 years, I think the only book I've ever known him to read was Hells Angels by Hunter S. Thompson - and he only read that because I told him he might think it was funny.

From a library perspective, I'm not worried that a change in book reading habits will lead to the end of libraries. Looking at things locally and in terms of numbers, our circulation is up by 20,000 items for the fiscal year so far, from October through July. More than 213,395 items have been checked out - an average of six items for each of Latah County's 35,000 residents.

If you are among the one in every four people who didn't read a book last year, it might surprise you to know that items we have for checkout include audiobooks, music CDs, DVDs and VHS tapes. And, there are all the resources available in the library itself - public computers, free wireless Internet access, as well as a variety of electronic resources that help patrons find information on everything from genealogy to car repair. We offer exciting programs and special events for children and adults, and, by the way, we also have books, hundreds of thousands of them, should you become interested in reading one

I don't know the circulation statistics for libraries nationwide, but the one cool library fact I do know is that in the United States there are more libraries than there are McDonald's restaurants.

The "doom" e-mail message kind of makes me think back to 1992, when half of my friends were telling me the world was coming to an end because Bill Clinton was elected President. Similarly in 2000, about half of my friends were telling me the end was coming because George Bush was. Well, we're still here, and libraries are still here, and I expect that's not going to change for a long time. So why not come on in to your local library and check out some of the great things we have to offer.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

